

Mapping Arguments for Better Decisions

Wacky Wednesdays · Professional Minds · Week 4

What exactly would have to be true for this conclusion to follow?

Reconstruct reasons, assumptions, and conclusions before arguing past one another.

Today's finish line

DO THIS See the core move.

WHAT THIS MEANS

Separate conclusion, premises, implicit premises, and the links between them.

DO THIS Try it on a bounded example.

WHAT THIS MEANS

A team proposes a new coding standard because “the old one causes bugs.” Map the evidence, the missing premise, and the decision.

DO THIS State evidence and limits.

WHAT THIS MEANS

A charitable argument map that makes support and uncertainty inspectable.

What does this prove, and what does it not prove?

DO THIS → WHAT THIS MEANS → FIND THIS YOURSELF → DEMAND DOCUMENTATION
VERIFY ON YOUR MACHINE → KEEP THE RECEIPT

The mental model

The idea

Arguments have conclusions and premises. Premises may be linked, independent, or intermediate; important premises can remain implicit.

The boundary

A map clarifies structure; it does not make weak evidence strong or settle a value judgment automatically.

FIND THIS YOURSELF

Before accepting a conclusion, name the observation that would support it.

A worked computing example

DO THIS Apply the idea to this bounded case: A team proposes a new coding standard because “the old one causes bugs.” Map the evidence, the missing premise, and the decision.

First pass

- ▶ What is known now?
- ▶ Which step or assumption is visible?
- ▶ Where is the checkpoint?

Professional move

Ask whether the observed bugs, the standard, and the proposed mechanism are connected by evidence or only by a memorable story.

Label the application: This is an instructor/computing translation, not a claim about the primary source.

What exactly would have to be true for this conclusion to follow?

Predict

What would you expect if the first story were incomplete?

Compare

What alternative explanation deserves a fair test?

PAIR TALK: Make one claim, one reason, and one uncertainty visible.

Do this: make the move visible

DO THIS Write the conclusion, list each premise, add the strongest implicit premise, and mark whether premises must work together.

1. Write the task, decision, or claim in one sentence.
2. Mark the relevant stages, evidence, comparison, or criteria.
3. Choose one checkpoint before you act or explain.
4. Say what would make you revise, stop, or continue.

VERIFY ON YOUR MACHINE A good first attempt leaves a receipt another person can inspect.

What the source supports — and its limits

Supports

- ▶ Reconstruction, principle of charity, explicit assumptions, and premise/conclusion structure improve the quality of disagreement.
- ▶ A clearer question and a more bounded next move.

Does not prove

Mapping is not a substitute for domain evidence, and charity does not mean accepting an unsupported premise.

Is this safe? Is this secure?

How do I know? Where can I verify that?

Recovery: when the first story fails

PAUSE

A failed check is information about the route.

Use one bounded recovery

1. Preserve the observation and context.
2. Name the assumption or step to inspect.
3. Make one smaller retry or ask for help.
4. Do not turn uncertainty into a confident story.

Watch for: Attacking a person, confusing an example with a premise, or treating an implicit assumption as already proven.

Keep the receipt

DO THIS Record the smallest useful evidence.

- ▶ Claim or decision
- ▶ Observation and context
- ▶ Reasoning / comparison / checkpoint
- ▶ Result, limit, and next action

Exit move

Map one decision you will make this week: conclusion, two premises, one assumption, and one evidence check.

KEEP THE RECEIPT A concise receipt beats a confident story.

Your next move

Map one decision you will make this week: conclusion, two premises, one assumption, and one evidence check.

How will you know?